

THE CONQUEST OF HAPPINESS

A DIAGNOSTIC OF THE MODERN CONDITION



Based on the work of Bertrand Russell

A Reading Deck designed for self-reflection.



The Reading of Faces

Russell invites you to stand in a busy street. Empty your mind of your own ego and let the personalities of the strangers take possession of you.

The Work Crowd	Anxiety, excessive concentration, dyspepsia, lack of interest in anything but the struggle.
The Pleasure Crowd	A grim resolve. The pursuit is conducted at a uniform pace; looking aside would cause an accident.

“Mark in every face I meet,
Marks of weakness, marks
of woe.” (Blake)

The Day-to-Day Unhappiness



We are not discussing great catastrophes—loss of children or public disgrace. We are discussing the unhappiness from which most people in civilized countries suffer.

**The Paradox:
Having no
obvious
external cause,
it appears
inescapable.**

CAUSES OF INFECTION

1. Mistaken views of the world.
2. Mistaken ethics.
3. Mistaken habits of life.

A Case Study in Recovery

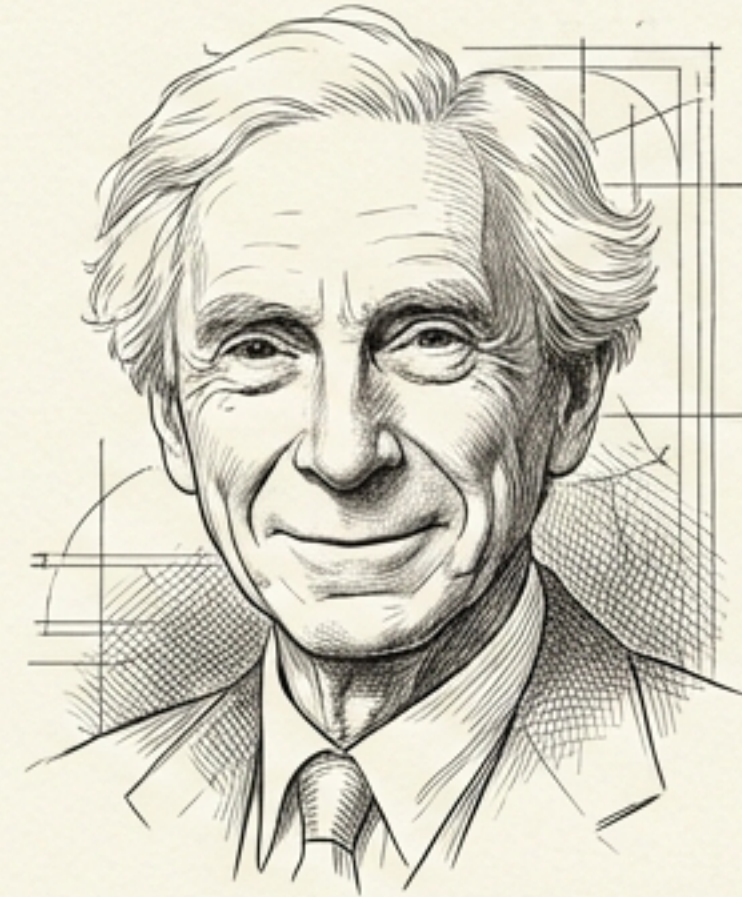
The Patient (Russell at 5)



“Weary of earth and laden with my sin.”

Hated life. Continually on the verge of suicide. Restrained only by the desire to know more mathematics.

The Cure (Russell in Old Age)



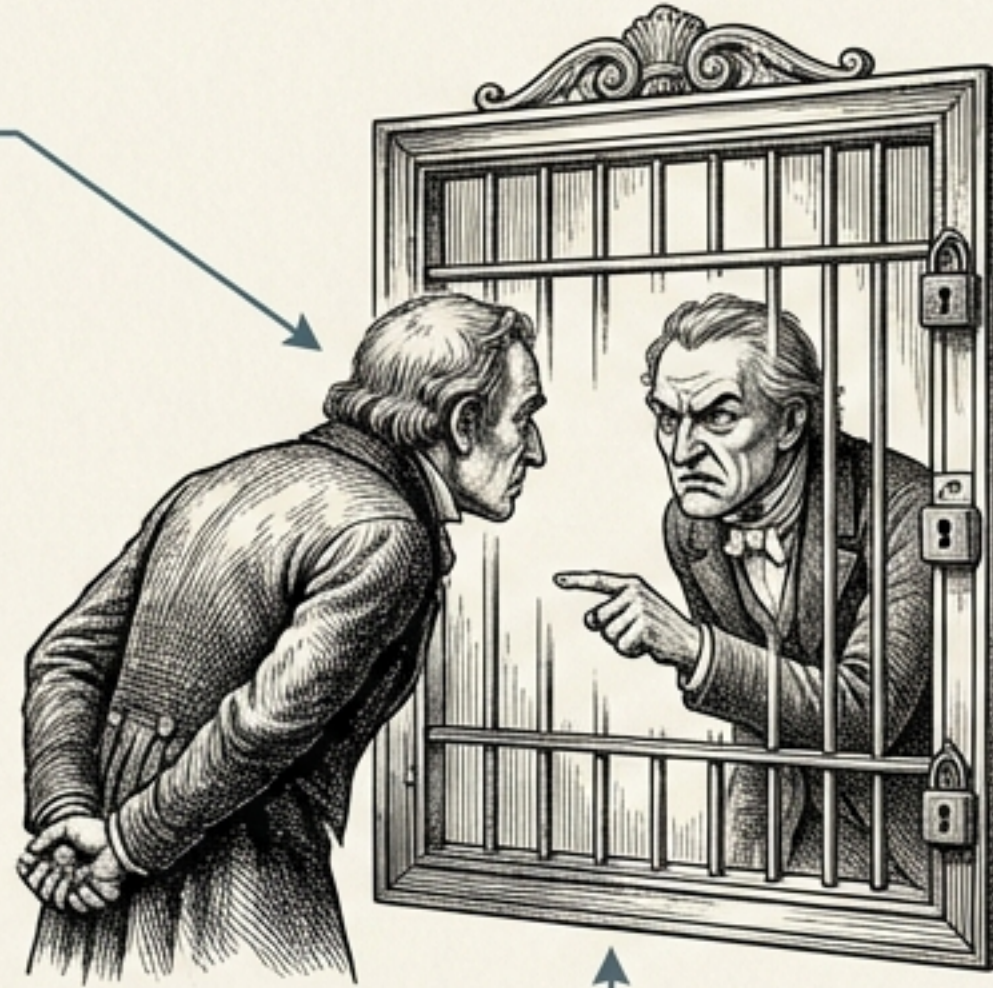
“I enjoy life; I might almost say that with every year that passes I enjoy it more.”

Achieved by dismissing the desire for the unattainable and diminishing preoccupation with the self.

The Root Cause: Self-Absorption

The Sinner

Perpetually meditating on sins. Trapped in guilt.



The Narcissist

Wishes to be admired, not to love. Eventually finds no satisfaction in the void of the self.

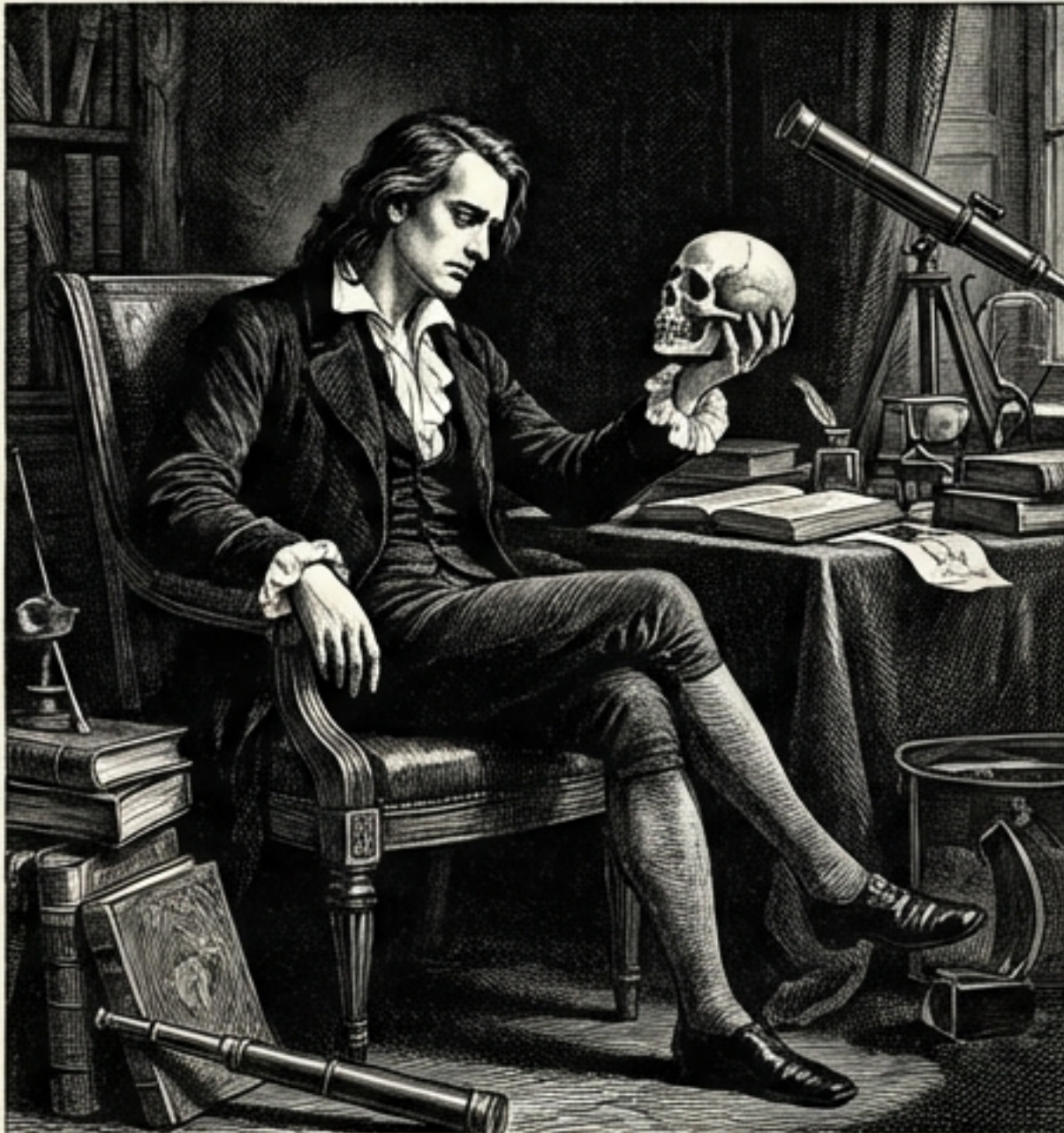
The Megalomaniac

Wishes to be powerful rather than charming.
Sees life as raw material for personal power.

Interest in oneself leads to no activity of a progressive kind.

The Intellectual Virus

Byronic Unhappiness



The Symptom:

The belief that he who increases knowledge increases sorrow.

The 'Wise' View:

Modern intellectuals claim they have “seen through” the enthusiasms of the past. They are proud of their unhappiness.

Russell's Diagnosis:

They are putting the cart before the horse. They are unhappy for some other reason, and then they invent a philosophy to justify it.

The 'Ecclesiastes' Fallacy



If Solomon could have heard the Queen of Sheba on the wireless, would it not have consoled him among his futile trees and pools?

The Argument: “All is vanity. There is no new thing under the sun.”

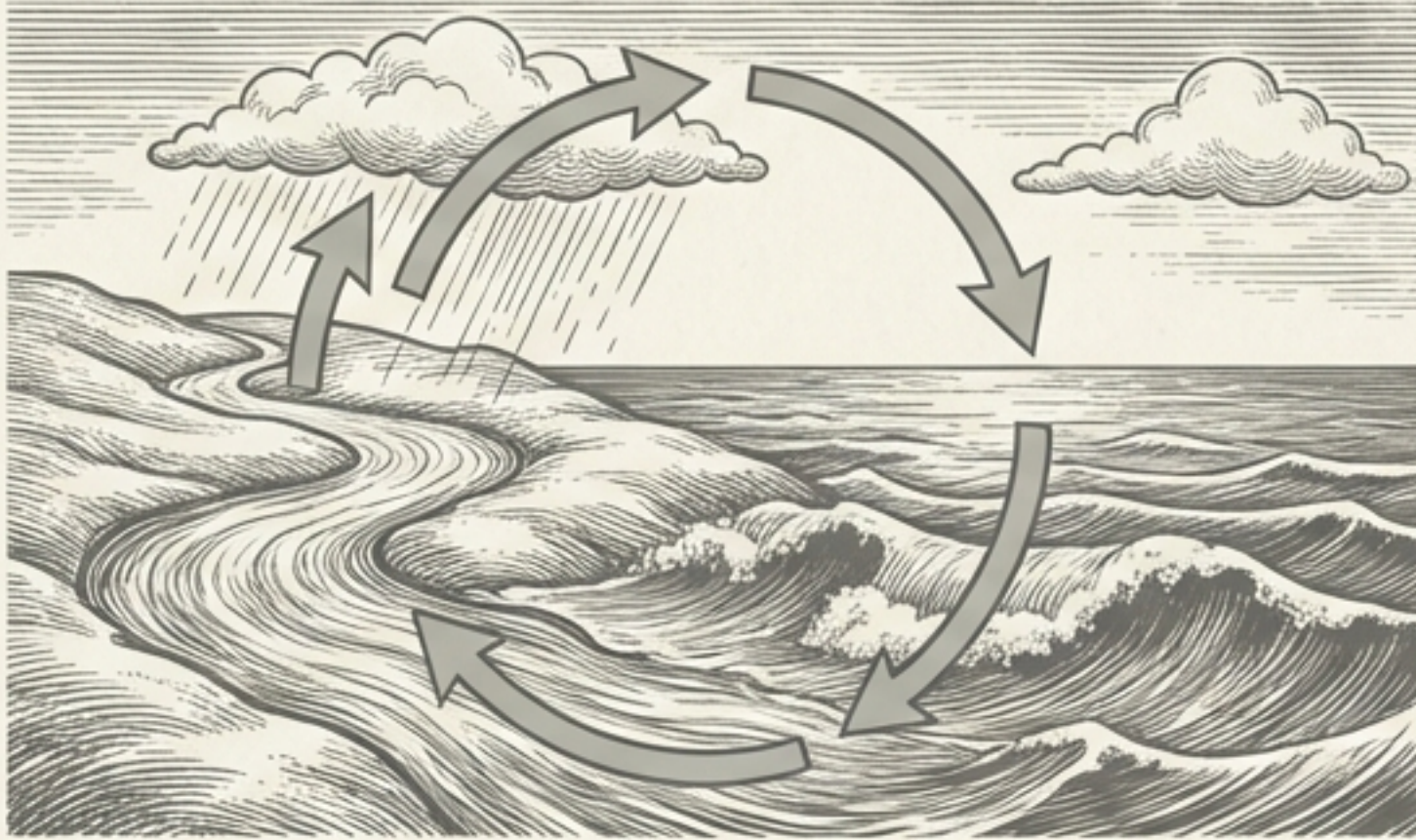
The Rebuttal: Solomon wasn't wise; he was just rich, bored, and idle.

Logic Check: You cannot argue with a mood. If a rich man loses his money, he no longer feels “all is vanity”—he feels his next meal is very important.

“The habit of looking to the future and thinking that the whole meaning of the present lies in what it will bring forth is a pernicious one.”

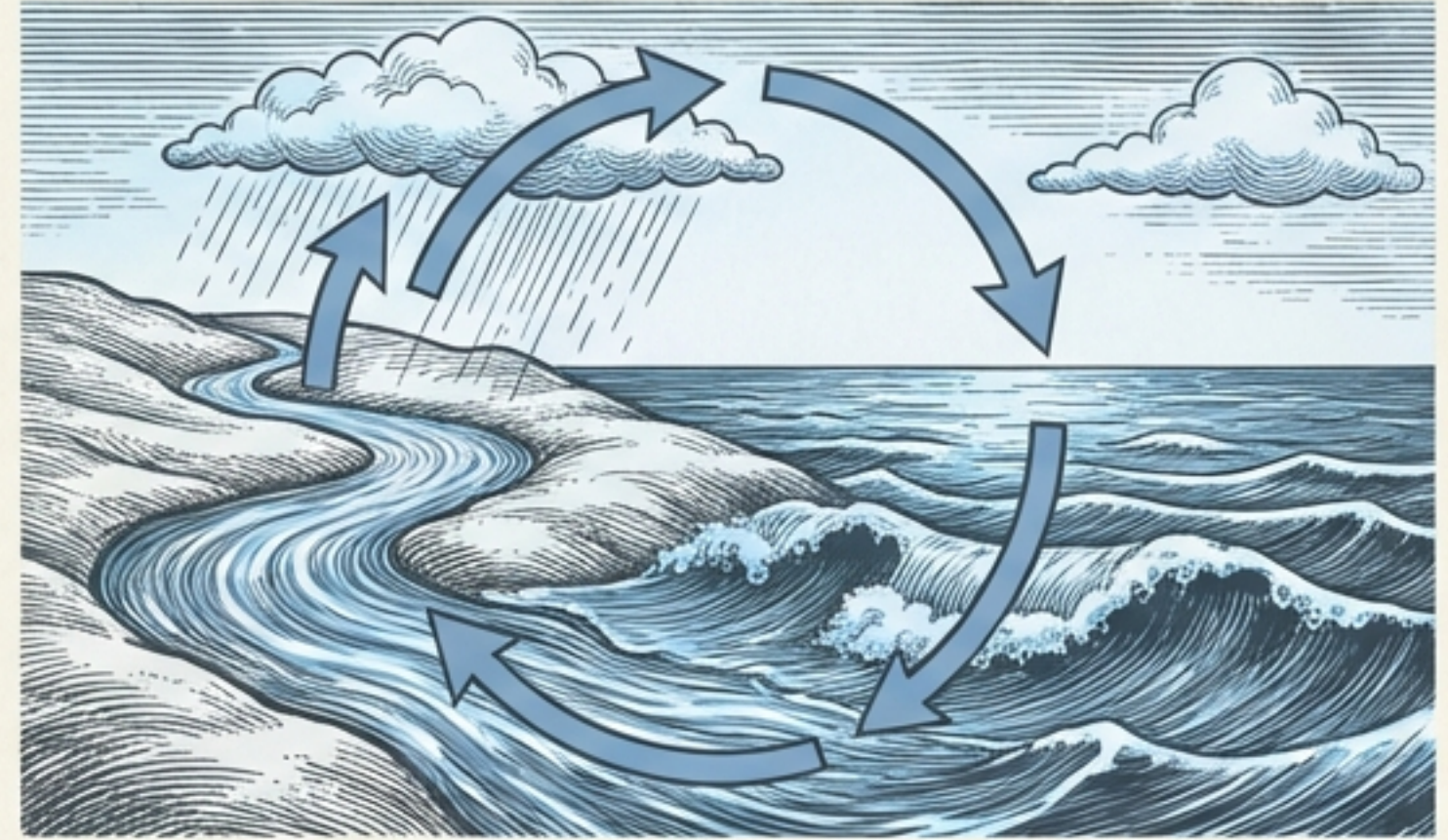
Reason Lays No Embargo on Happiness

The Pessimist's Logic



Rivers run into the sea, yet the sea is not full.
The cycle is endless and futile.

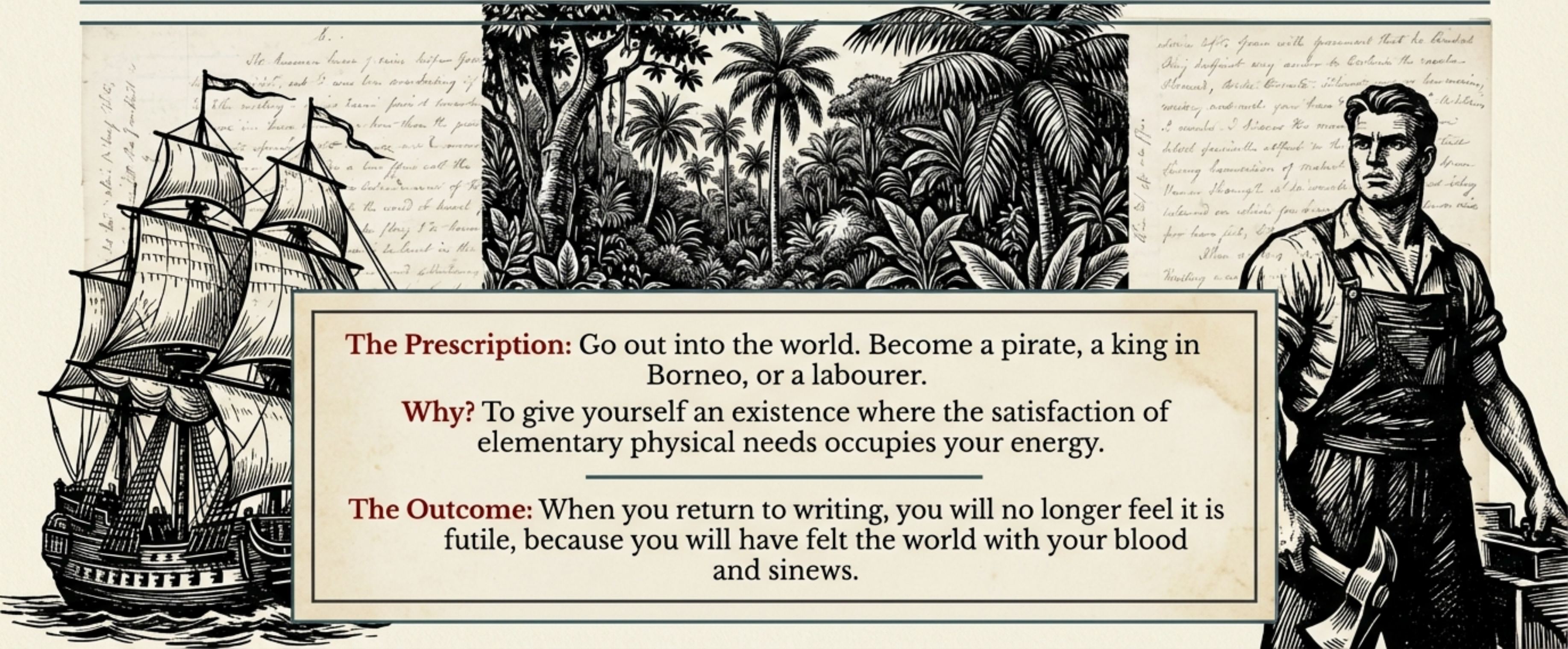
The Optimist's Logic



If the waters were endowed with feeling, they
would enjoy the adventurous cycle. Successors
enjoying the fruits of labor is natural, not tragic.

Verdict: If moods were decided by reason, there is just as much reason for cheerfulness as for despair.

The Cure for Intellectual Despair



The Prescription: Go out into the world. Become a pirate, a king in Borneo, or a labourer.

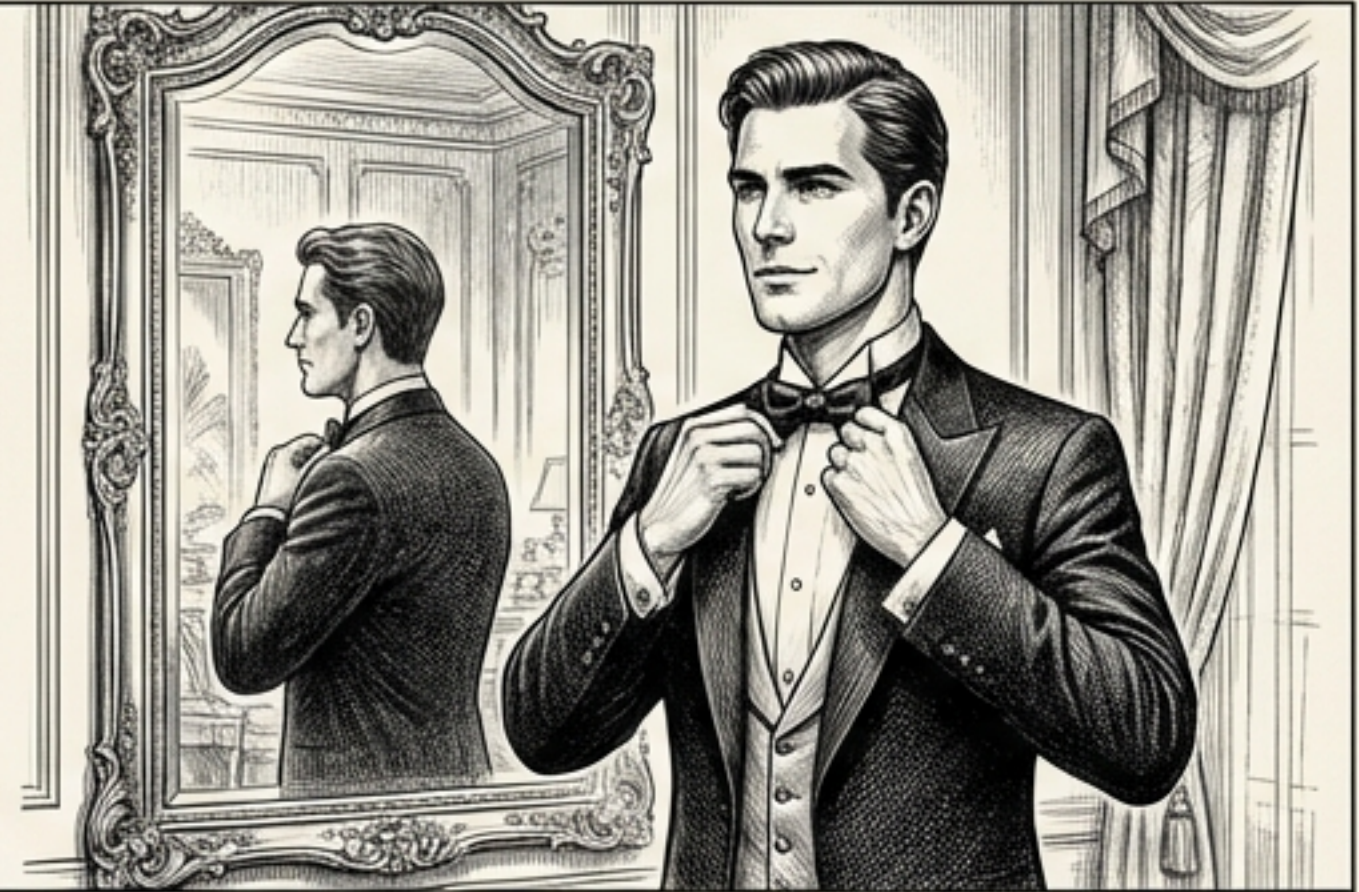
Why? To give yourself an existence where the satisfaction of elementary physical needs occupies your energy.

The Outcome: When you return to writing, you will no longer feel it is futile, because you will have felt the world with your blood and sinews.

The 'Struggle for Life' Hoax



Actual Struggle for Life (Survival).



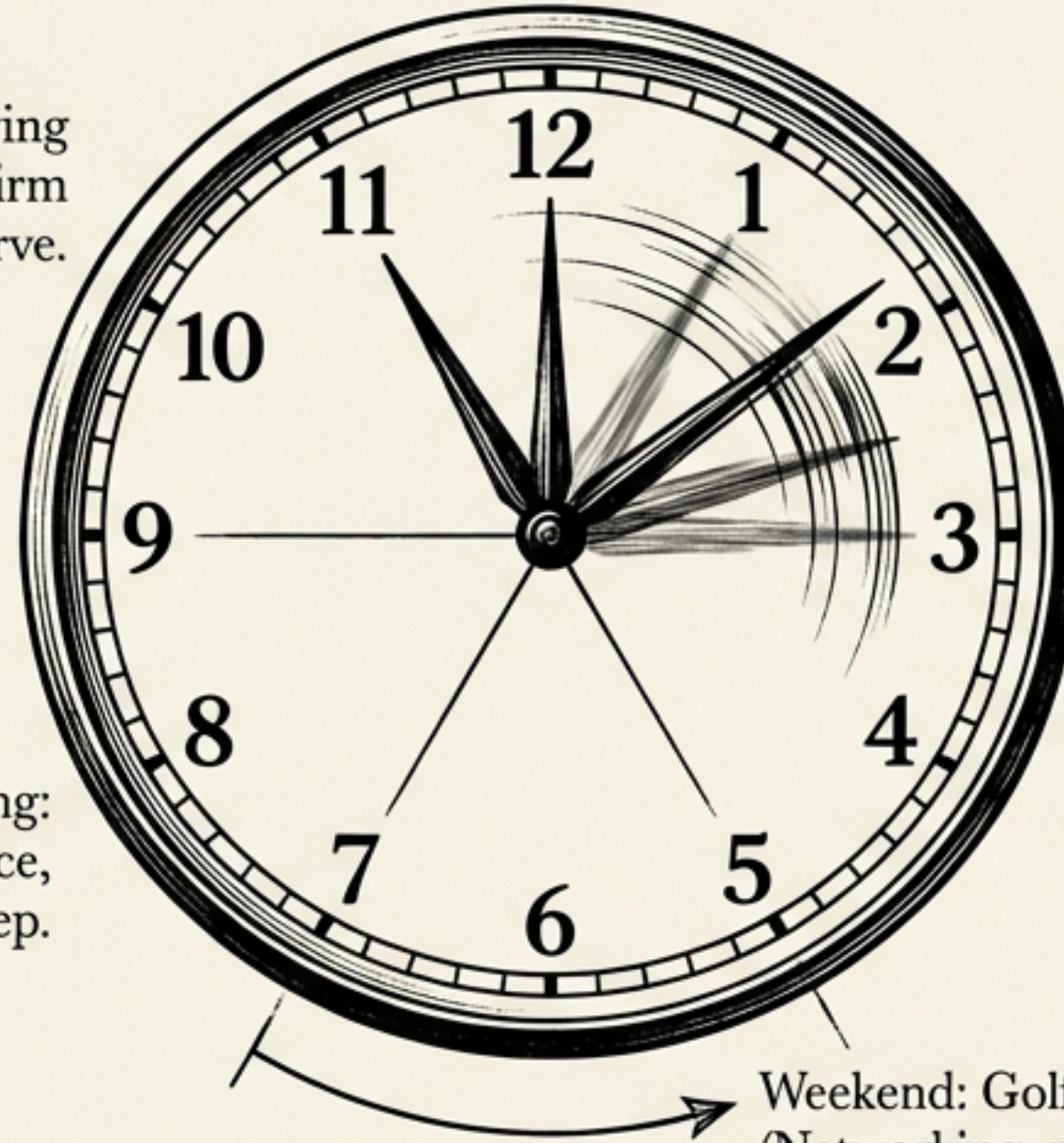
Modern Struggle for Life (Success).

- **The Complaint:** Businessmen say they are caught in a “struggle for life.”
- **The Reality:** No one in the modern middle class is fighting for their next meal.
- **The True Fear:** They do not fear starving; they **fear failing to outshine** their neighbors.

The One-Hundred-Yard Dash to the Grave

The Office: Displaying executive qualities. Firm jaw. Sagacious reserve.

Morning: Hurries to office, wife asleep.



Evening: Tired. Pretending to enjoy ladies' company.

Weekend: Golf links (Networking, not leisure).

The Result: He knows nothing of his children. He has no true friends.
He knows 'springtime and harvest' only as they affect the market.

The Desiccation of the Soul



The **Logic of Competition**: Everything is measured by pecuniary value.

- Reading: "Books seem futile."
- Music: "Highbrow."
- Travel: "The American businessman in Europe is utterly bored, wondering what is happening in the office or the baseball world."

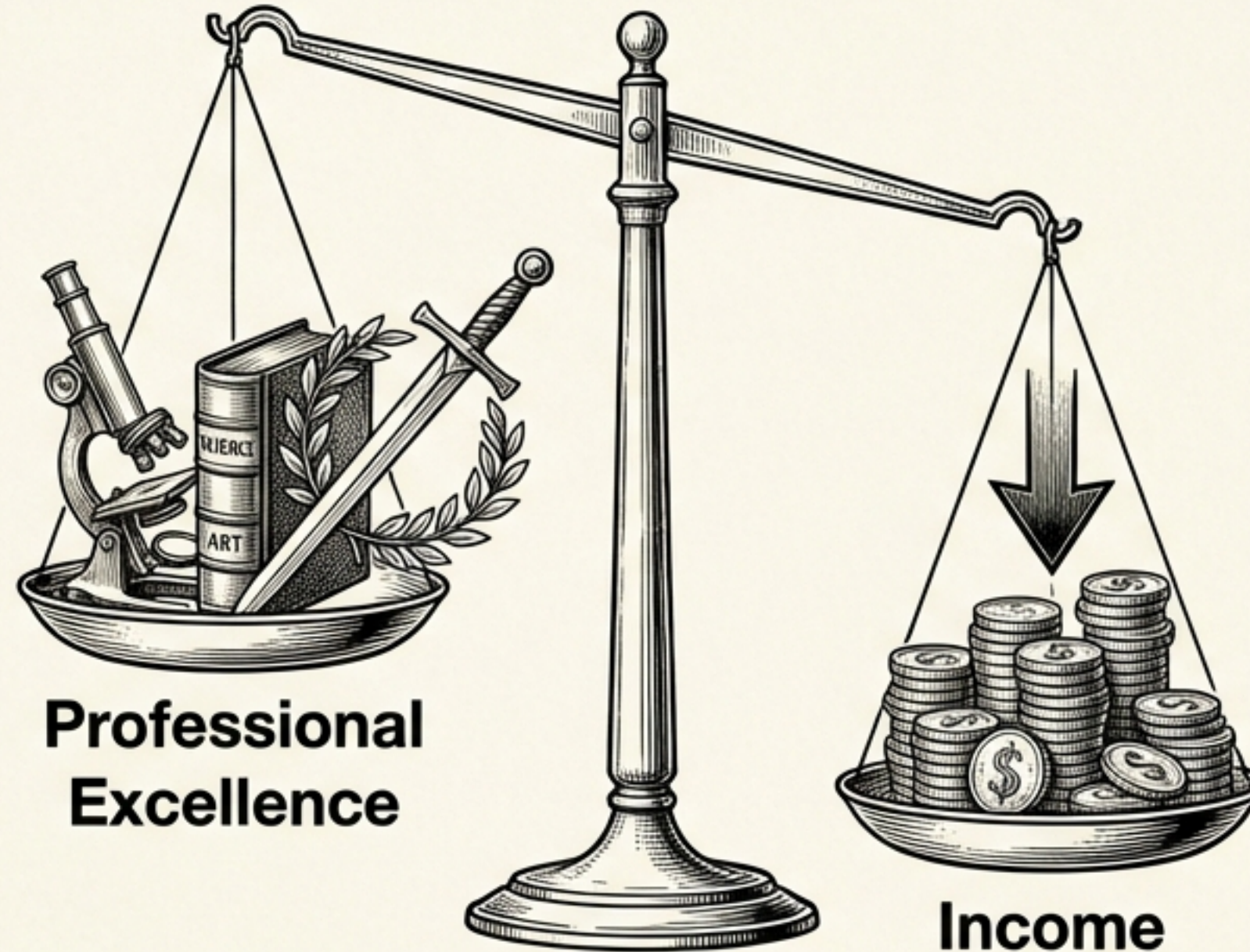
The Tragedy: He is a **victim of his own philosophy**. He has cultivated the will at the expense of the **senses and the intellect**.

The Religion of Success

Europe:

Professional excellence (Science, Army, Navy) is respected regardless of income.

Poverty can be an honor.



America: Money is the accepted measure of brains. A professor is merely a “**hired servant**” of the businessman.

Check Yourself: Do you value your profession for its excellence, or its income?

Competition Invades Leisure



The Two Motives for Reading:

1. Enjoyment (The Leisurely Art).
2. **To Boast** (The Competitive Art).

The Modern Approach:

Ladies read the “**selected**” books of the month to keep up socially. Masterpieces like *Hamlet* or *King Lear* are never selected by Book Clubs.

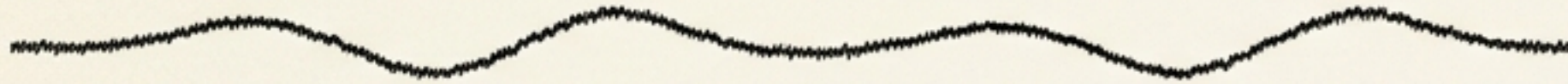
The Cost:

The art of general conversation is **dead**.

The Fear of Boredom

Physical Boredom (Winter Evenings)

A



Mental Excitement (Movies, Radio)

B



Mental Excitement (Movies, Radio)

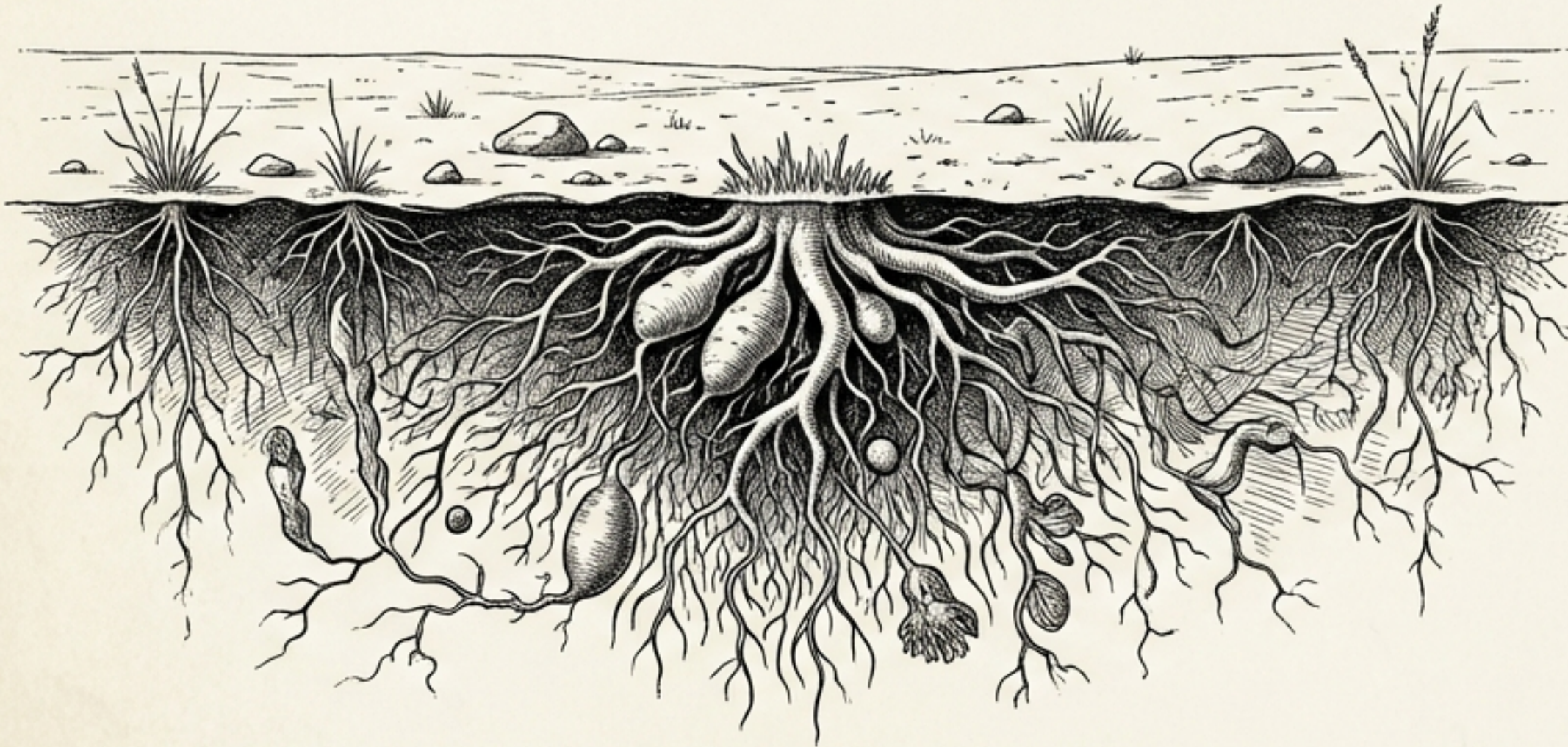
The Paradox: We are **less bored** than our ancestors, but **more afraid** of boredom.

The Diagnosis: We believe boredom is **unnatural**. We seek excitement as a **constant state**.

The Addiction: Continuous excitement is like a **drug**; it raises the threshold. You eventually need **stronger doses** to feel anything.

In Praise of Fruitful Monotony

Monotony



Fruitful

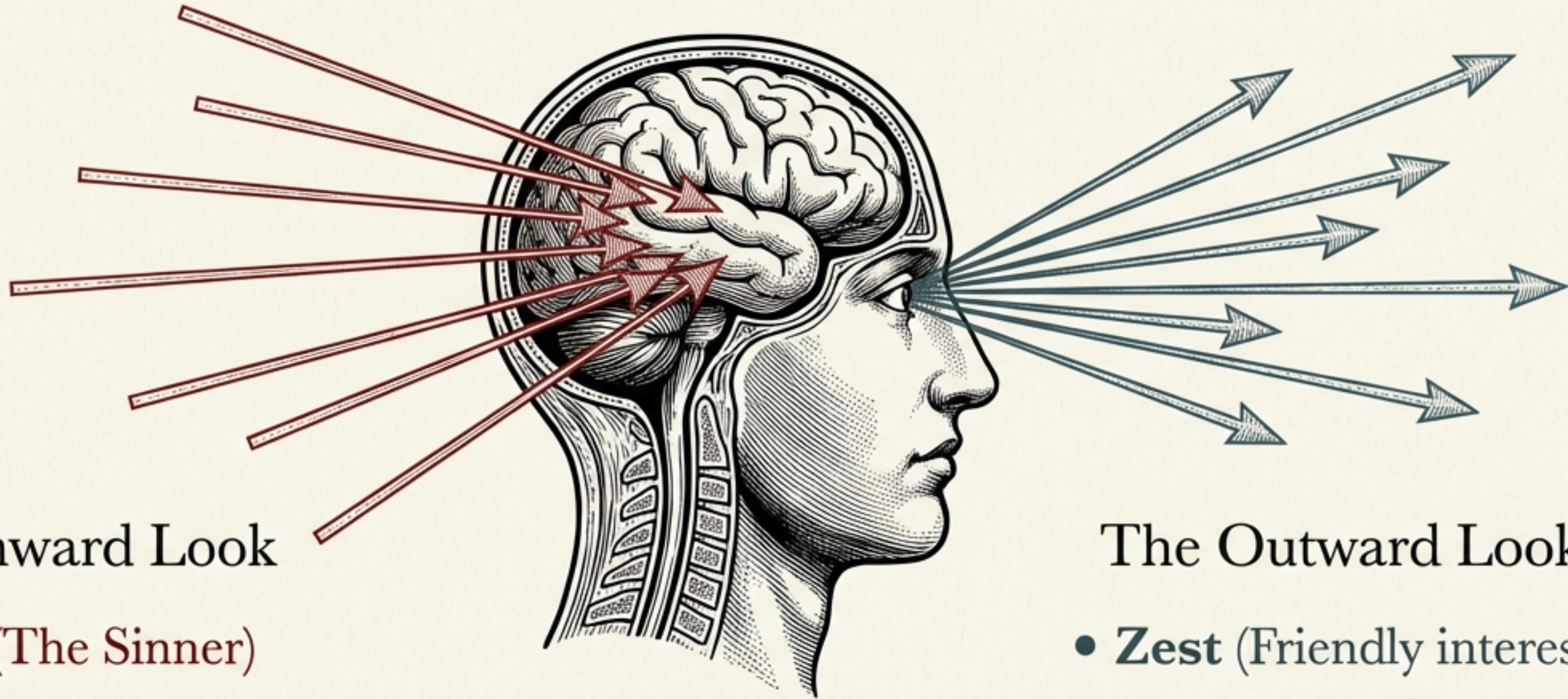
The Insight: A happy life must be to a great extent a **quiet life**.

The Evidence: Great books contain **boring portions**. Great lives contain **uninteresting stretches**.

Example: If a modern publisher saw the **Old Testament**, he would cut the **genealogies**—and miss the point.

Takeaway: One must be able to endure the '**fallow**' periods to produce something of value.

The Prognosis



The Inward Look

- **Guilt** (The Sinner)
- **Vanity** (The Narcissist)
- **Greed** (The Competitor)

The Shift in Focus

The Outward Look

- **Zest** (Friendly interest)
- **Affection** (Giving love)
- **Work** (Constructive activity)

The Biological Cure: Love

Why Love Matters:

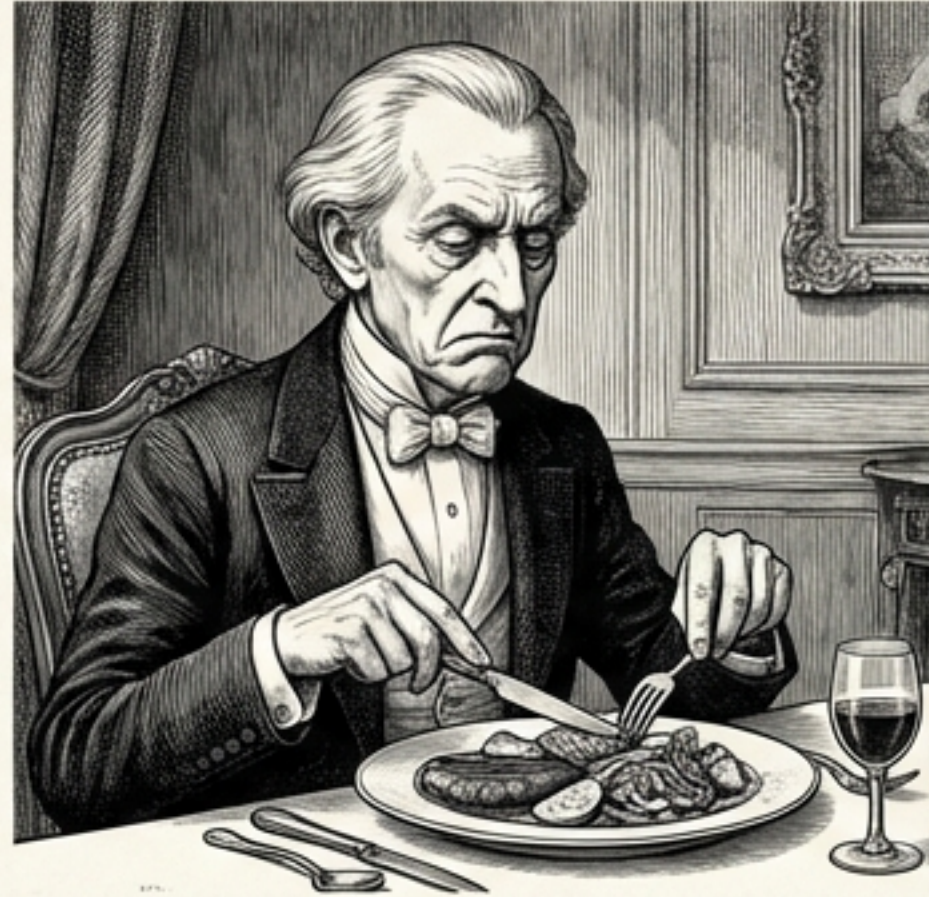
1. **Source of Delight:** “He was merely enjoying himself.”
2. **Enhancer:** It enhances all other pleasures (music, mountains, the sea).
3. **Ego-Breaker:** It is a form of **biological cooperation**. It breaks the “hard shell of the ego.”



The Failure of **Solitary Philosophies:** **Stoicism** and **self-reliance** are **insufficient**. Man depends on **cooperation**.

‘Cultivating Zest’

The Dyspeptic



The Zestful



The **Metaphor**: The difference between a healthy appetite and a dyspeptic one.

The **Happy Man**: The one who has the most ‘appetite’ for the universe. He retains a natural curiosity about the world, unhindered by the ‘sins’ of the ego.

Happiness is a **Conquest**



Happiness is not a gift of the gods. It is not something that simply happens to you. It is a **conquest**. It requires effort to:

- Dismiss the “sins” of **self-absorption**.
- Refuse the “religion” of **competition**.
- Embrace the world outside yourself.

“The man who has not **read good books** has no mental life... The man who seeks **intoxication** has given up hope except in oblivion.”

